

FIELD LIBRARY / ACTION CHECKLIST

Flooding

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Move to higher ground if water is rising or a flash-flood warning affects you. Never walk, swim, or drive through floodwater; depth, current, contamination, and road damage are hard to judge. Follow evacuation orders and avoid basements or low areas that can fill rapidly.

Do now.

- ☐ **Get above the water**
01 Leave low ground and move to a safe higher location. If a road is flooded, turn around and choose another route.
- ☐ **Read the local notice**
02 Check alerts, road closures, and evacuation instructions. Do not rely on the road being open because it was open earlier.
- ☐ **Keep away from hazards**
03 Floodwater may hide energized wires, debris, sewage, chemicals, and missing road surface. Keep children and pets away.
- ☐ **If trapped, call for help**
04 Give your precise location to emergency services. Move to a higher level if possible; avoid entering a closed attic where you could become trapped by rising water.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Identify higher ground reachable without crossing water. Pack essentials while routes remain dry; if they are already cut off, use the safest elevated space available and signal for help. Stay out of a basement that is taking on water.

Watch for.

Flooding can begin far from the heaviest rain. Do not attempt to cross flowing water to reach a vehicle, home, or belongings.

People & practical needs.

Account for children, older people, pets and anyone who needs assistance before moving. Keep shoes, medicines and a torch in the shelter area

Next decision.

Return only when officials say it is safe. Photograph damage without entering unstable structures, use protective gear for cleanup, and check the water supply for advisories.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

[Ready.gov](#) · [Floods](#)

[CDC](#) · [Floodwater safety](#)

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/flooding/>